



A carving of the central Aztec deity Quetzalcoatl in Teotihuacán located near present-day Mexico City.

FOLLOWING THE OTTOMAN

CONQUEST of Constantinople in 1453, its conqueror, **Mehmed II**, set out not merely to extend Ottoman rule in the Balkans, but also to reassert it in Anatolia, where Ottoman strength had been significantly reduced in the wake of Timur's early 15th-century invasion (see 1401–03). It was now most obviously opposed in the region by a Turcoman people, the **White Sheep Turcomans**, under the rule of **Uzun Hasan**. They had been actively, if not particularly successfully, wooed by various

Christian powers, notably Venice, in an attempt to enlist them in Christian struggles against Ottoman expansion. The result of Uzun Hasan's efforts was a comprehensive defeat in 1473 at the **Battle of Otlukbeli**, the light cavalry of the Turcoman forces swept aside by the Ottomans' overwhelming firepower.

By the mid-1470s, the territories of Burgundy were at their height. Their heartlands were the **Duchy and County of Burgundy**, awarded to the first duke of Burgundy, Philip the Bold, brother

of King **Charles V of France**, in 1363. In 1369, with his marriage to Margaret, the countess of Flanders, Philip also acquired **Flanders and Artois**—in effect a significant portion of modern-day **Belgium**. To this constellation of territories, Philip's grandson, **Philip the Good**, then added parts of northeast France and much of modern Holland. These holdings, however imposing, were still far from

Ottoman drums

The Janissaries of the Ottoman army parade with the drums that were used to urge the soldiers into battle.

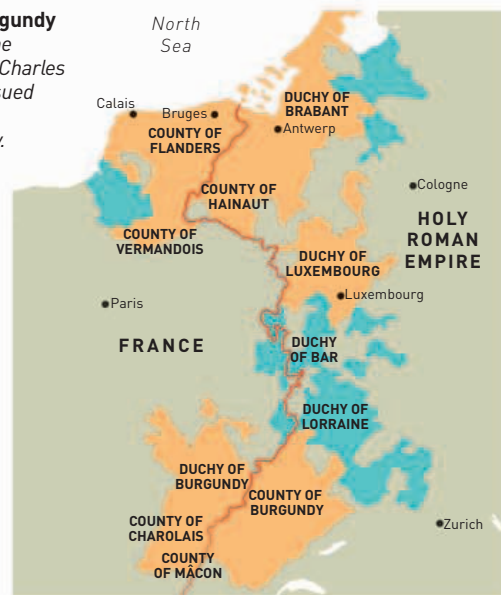


Expansion of Burgundy

This map shows the territories held by Charles the Bold, who pursued an aggressive expansionist policy. The duchies of Bar and Lorraine gave Charles an almost continuous stretch of land by 1475.

KEY

- Territories held 1467
- Territories added by 1475
- Border of Holy Roman Empire



being a single, continuous territory. Furthermore, as many of them were within the **Holy Roman Empire**, these were at least theoretically subject to the Holy Roman Emperor, just as Burgundy's French lands were nominally subject to the king of France. But their size and, crucially, the fact that they held many of the richest of the burgeoning trading centres of the **Low Countries** made the Burgundians a formidable power. Philip the Good's heir, **Charles the Bold**, inherited this state within states in 1467 and determined not just to make it a continuous territory—which by 1472 he had succeeded in doing through an audacious combination of purchase and

conquest—but to assert its independence as a separate kingdom. The Burgundians were inevitably opposed by the infinitely more calculating French king, Louis XI. In little more than four months in 1476, they suffered two calamitous defeats by **Swiss mercenary armies** in the pay of Louis—at Grandson and at Morat in modern northwest Switzerland.

The rigidly hierarchical **Aztec Empire** (1428–1521) became a formidable military force, imposing itself with brutal finality on its neighbors in **central Mexico** from **Tenochtitlan**, its capital. **Axayacatl**, who came to the Aztec throne in 1469, added substantially to the empire, mainly with the conquest of the state of **Tlatalolco** in 1473.



IN JANUARY 1477, CHARLES THE BOLD'S Burgundian forces confronted the Swiss again, at **Nancy** in Lorraine. They were comprehensively routed and the body of the duke was discovered face down in a frozen pond. While **Louis XI** (see 1461) seized the Burgundians' French territories, those in the Low Countries passed to the Habsburgs with the marriage of Charles's only child, Margaret, to the future Holy Roman Emperor, Maximilian I.

William Caxton (c. 1420–92) was an English merchant whose continental travels introduced him to printing. He established the **first printing press in England** in 1476, printing the first book a year later. He published 87 books, many also translated by him.



Caxton's printing press

The first printing press in England, established by William Caxton in Westminster, London, produced its first book in 1477.

1472 Portuguese discover island of Fernando Po off West African coast

1472 First publication of the Etymologies of Bishop Isidore of Seville, first Christian encyclopedia

August 11, 1473 Ottomans defeat Turcomans at Battle of Otlukbeli

1474 Austrian Habsburgs forced to recognize independence of Swiss League

1474 Treaty of Utrecht grants Hanseatic League major trading advantages in England

March 2, 1476 Swiss defeat Burgundians at Grandson, Switzerland

June 22, 1476 Swiss defeat Burgundians at Morat, Switzerland

January 5, 1477 Burgundians defeated at Battle of Nancy: death of Charles the Bold (b. 1433)

1473 Aztecs defeat and annex Tlatalolco

1473 Venetians destroy Smyrna and take Cyprus

1474 Territories of Novgorod incorporated into the Grand Duchy of Muscovy

1475 Burgundian expansion at its height under Charles the Bold

1476 Incas conquer south coast of Peru

1477 Louis XI of France initiates Royal postal Service to speed royal communications